

the wild before and during the flowering period. It has also been cultivated as a vegetable.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Miner's lettuce is rich in vitamin C.

History & Folklore Miner's lettuce was a readily available salad vegetable on the West Coast of America. It most probably acquired its name during the California gold rush of 1849. Itinerant miners may have later taken the plant with them to Australia, where it is now common.



Miner's lettuce may have been spread around the world by itinerant miners.

Medicinal Actions & Uses

Apart from its value as a vegetable, miner's lettuce, like its relative purslane (*Portulaca oleracea*, p. 255), may also be taken as an invigorating spring tonic and an effective diuretic.

Morinda citrifolia (Rubiaceae)

Noni, Indian Mulberry

Description Shrub or small tree, growing to 26 ft (8 m), with 4-angled stems, and elliptical to oval leaves to 14 in (35 cm) long. Large creamy-white flowers produce a fruit resembling a breadfruit, about 4¾ in (12 cm) long, green turning yellow to white, with a pungent, very unpleasant odor.

Habitat & Cultivation Originally native only to Southeast Asia, noni has spread to India in the west and across the Pacific to eastern Polynesia and Hawaii. It prefers volcanic soils in coastal areas and lowland forests up to about 1,300 ft (400 m) above sea level, and until recently was infrequently cultivated. The fruit is gathered when ripe; other parts of the tree are picked as required.

Parts Used Fruit and juice, leaves, bark.

Constituents Noni fruit contains polysaccharides, coumarins, iridoids, flavonoids and alkaloids. No active compounds unique to noni have been identified.

History & Folklore Different parts of the plant have been used in Polynesia for at least 2,000 years, chiefly to counter infection and to treat

chronic disease. For example, noni leaves are used to treat boils and stomach ulcers and, chewed, are applied as a poultice to relieve inflammation. In Hawaii, traditional healers have long used noni in order to promote recovery from bouts of serious illness.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Since the late 1990s, word of noni's reputed medicinal benefits has spread and noni is being presented as a medicinal food with an astonishing variety of potential uses. These include treating obesity, diabetes, cancer, pain, lowered immunity, high blood pressure, heart disease, and depression. With lists like this, many people are justifiably skeptical about noni's value as a medicinal food. Nonetheless, noni fruit and juice is highly unlikely to do harm and may well prove useful in treating chronic illness, including pain, inflammatory disorders, heart and circulatory problems, and cancer. Traditionally, juice from the fruit is used as a mouthwash and gargle for infections in the mouth and throat. Noni juice is probably best drunk on an empty stomach.

Research The limited research into noni suggests that it may support immune function and be useful in treating chronic inflammation. A 2012 review of noni research concluded that the fruit "may have a small degree of anticancer activity." One theory advanced is that noni contains appreciable levels of proxeronine, which the body needs to produce xeronine. This alkaloid appears to enable cells throughout the body to counter inflammation, promote healing, and support cellular regulation. In times of stress or infection, the body's need for xeronine increases, and many people are thought to lack sufficient proxeronine to maintain adequate xeronine levels.

Morinda officinalis (Rubiaceae)

Morinda, Ba Ji Tian (Chinese)

Description Deciduous plant with white flowers and a root that yields a yellow dye.

Habitat & Cultivation Morinda is native to China. It is cultivated in Guangdong, Guangxi, and Fujian provinces. The root is unearthed in early spring.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Morinda contains anthraquinones, terpenoids, and polysaccharides.

History & Folklore The earliest written record of morinda's use is in the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ngong Bencaojing*) of the 1st century CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Pungent and sweet-tasting, morinda root is an important tonic herb within traditional Chinese medicine. It has hormonal and antidepressant properties. As a sexual tonic, it is commonly used to treat impotence

and premature ejaculation in men, and is taken by both sexes to aid fertility. Morinda is employed in various other conditions, notably in the treatment of menstrual disorders. Researchers are investigating the root for its potential to prevent bone loss and help in treating osteoporosis.

Morus alba (Moraceae)

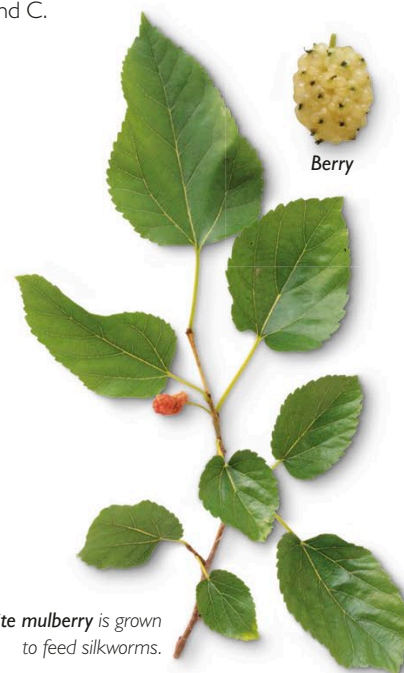
White Mulberry, Sang Ye (Chinese)

Description Deciduous tree growing to about 49 ft (15 m). Has toothed leaves, flowers in catkins, and white berries.

Habitat & Cultivation White mulberry is native to China. It is grown worldwide as a garden ornamental. The leaves are gathered in late autumn, the twigs in early summer, and the berries when ripe in summer. The root is dug up in winter.

Parts Used Leaves, twigs, fruit, root bark.

Constituents The leaves contain flavonoids, anthocyanins, and artocapin. The flavonoids are antioxidant. The fruit contains the vitamins A, B₁, B₂, and C.



White mulberry is grown to feed silkworms.

History & Folklore White mulberry has been cultivated for over 5,000 years for its leaves (*sang ye*), the preferred food of the silkworm. The silkworm's feces are used in Chinese medicine to treat vomiting.

Medicinal Actions & Uses White mulberry leaves are expectorant, encouraging the loosening and coughing up of phlegm, and are prescribed in China as a treatment for coughs. The leaves are also taken to treat fever, sore and inflamed eyes, sore throats, headaches, dizziness and vertigo.